# Aurora Labs Employee Handbook

Effective date: 1 January 2026

## 1. Welcome to Aurora Labs

This handbook describes how we work at Aurora Labs. It covers the things every employee needs to know about time off, expenses, how the company is organised, how we review performance, and what we expect when someone joins us. It is written to be read once and then used as a reference.

Aurora Labs builds routing and scheduling software for regional freight operators. The company was founded in 2019 and is remote friendly, with two offices and a largely distributed workforce. The handbook applies to every regular employee. Contractors follow the terms of their own agreement, which is issued separately by People Operations.

This handbook is not a contract of employment. Where anything in this handbook conflicts with an individual employment agreement, the employment agreement takes precedence. We update the handbook from time to time and we tell employees when we do.

## 2. Reporting structure and manager duties

Every employee reports to a direct manager. Managers report to a department lead, and department leads report to the chief executive. The full organisation chart is published on the intranet and is updated within five working days of any change.

Aurora Labs is organised into four departments. Engineering builds and maintains the product. Operations runs customer onboarding and day to day support. Commercial covers sales and partnerships. Corporate covers People Operations, Finance and Legal.

Managers at Aurora Labs have specific duties that the company takes seriously. A manager runs a weekly one to one with every direct report, and uses it for the employee's questions rather than as a status update. A manager sets clear goals at the start of each quarter and gives written feedback at the middle and end of each quarter. A manager approves or declines time off requests within two working days of receiving them, and approves or declines expense claims within five working days.

A manager is also responsible for the development of their reports. That means having a career conversation at least twice a year, approving the learning budget described in the benefits guide, and raising a pay review when an employee's scope has clearly grown. If an employee feels their manager is not meeting these duties, they may raise it with the department lead or with People Operations, and the company does not treat such a raise as a complaint against the employee.

## 3. Performance reviews

Aurora Labs runs a performance review cycle twice a year, once in the spring and once in the autumn. Each cycle has three parts: a self assessment written by the employee, a written assessment by the manager, and a calibration session where department leads compare ratings across teams so that standards are applied consistently.

The self assessment asks the employee to describe what they shipped, what they learned, and where they struggled. It is not a form to be filled in casually, and the time spent on it is protected work, not something to do out of hours.

Ratings are on a three point scale: exceeds, meets, and developing. A rating of exceeds means the employee operated beyond the scope of their level for the whole period, not that they had one good month. A rating of developing means the manager and the employee have already discussed a plan, because no employee should first learn about a problem during a review.

Pay adjustments take effect from the first of the month following the review and are announced to the employee in a one to one, never by email. An employee who disagrees with a rating may ask for it to be reconsidered within ten working days of receiving it, and People Operations reviews the case.

## 4. Paid time off

Every regular full time employee accrues paid time off at a rate of ten hours for each full month worked, which is one hundred and twenty hours, or fifteen days, across a full year. Part time employees accrue pro rata based on their contracted hours. Accrual begins on the first day of employment and is shown on the monthly payslip.

Paid time off is intended for rest, holidays and personal matters. It is not intended for use when you are working for another company, and the company asks employees to tell their manager if they plan to do any paid work elsewhere so that conflicts of interest can be checked.

Carryover is capped. An employee may carry over a maximum of forty hours, or five days, of unused paid time off into the following calendar year. Any unused balance above forty hours is lost on 31 December. The company tracks accrual throughout the year and warns employees in November when they are close to the cap and at risk of losing hours.

Time off is requested through the expense and leave system, which notifies the employee's manager. Requests for three days or fewer need the manager's approval only. Requests of four days or more need the manager's approval and a short note explaining how the employee's work will be covered, so that the manager can plan rather than simply approve.

Sick leave is separate from paid time off. An employee who is unwell does not use their paid time off for sick days, and the two are tracked separately in the leave system.

## 5. Expenses and the approval chain

Aurora Labs reimburses reasonable costs that an employee incurs to do their job. Every claim is submitted through the expense system with a receipt attached, and claims must be filed within sixty days of the expense being incurred. A claim filed late may be declined at the company's discretion.

Expenses follow an approval chain based on how much the expense is worth. Expenses of up to two hundred and fifty dollars are approved by the employee's direct manager. Expenses from two hundred and fifty dollars up to one thousand dollars are approved by the employee's department lead. Expenses of one thousand dollars or more are approved by Finance, who will ask for a written justification above two thousand five hundred dollars. No employee may approve their own expense, and a manager may not approve an expense for their own direct report without a second approver.

There are also limits on what the company will spend in common categories. Meals while travelling are reimbursed up to forty five dollars per day in the employee's normal country of work, and up to sixty dollars per day when travelling internationally. Hotel accommodation is reimbursed up to two hundred and twenty dollars per night in most cities, and up to three hundred dollars per night in the small number of cities where the company has agreed a higher rate with a partner hotel chain. Ground transport is reimbursed in full when it is the practical option, and first class rail travel is permitted for journeys over three hours.

Some expenses need approval before the money is spent, not after. Any single purchase over one thousand dollars, any software subscription, and any contractor engagement must be approved in writing in advance by Finance, even if the eventual cost would have fallen under a manager's own limit. An unapproved large purchase may be declined in full, and the employee would carry the cost, so it is always worth asking first.

Personal expenses are not reimbursable. That includes commuting to a normal office, family holidays, gym memberships covered elsewhere in the benefits guide, and any fines or penalties incurred while working.

## 6. Joining Aurora Labs

New hires go through a structured onboarding period of their first four weeks. The aim is that a new colleague understands how the company works and has everything they need to do real work by the end of their first week, rather than spending a month chasing equipment and introductions.

Equipment is ordered as soon as an employment contract is signed. People Operations places the order within two working days of signature, and the standard laptop is configured and tested by IT before the employee's start date. A new hire who receives a laptop after starting should raise it with IT the same day, because that is a process failure rather than something to wait out.

Every new hire is assigned an onboarding buddy, who is a colleague outside their direct reporting line. The buddy's job is to answer the small questions that a new joiner does not want to ask their manager, and to check in at the end of the first week and the end of the first month.

The first week includes an introduction to each department, a walk through of the product, and a session with People Operations covering the benefits guide and the expense system. New hires are expected to complete their security training in their first week, which covers the password rules, device enrolment and the incident reporting process described in the information security policy.

Probation lasts three months. At the end of probation the manager holds a short review covering how the onboarding went and whether the role is a good fit, and People Operations confirms the outcome in writing. Probation is a two way process, and an employee who feels the role is not what was described at interview should say so early rather than at the end.

## 7. Parental leave

Aurora Labs supports employees who become parents. The length of parental leave and the rate of pay during that leave are set out in the benefits guide, which employees should read alongside this section. This section describes the notification and approval process that an employee must follow to take parental leave, and the steps the company takes in response.

An employee who is expecting a child, or who is going through adoption or foster placement, must give written notice to People Operations. The notice period depends on how far away the expected date is. If the

expected date is more than fifteen weeks away, the employee must give notice at or before the end of the fifteenth week before that date. If the expected date is closer than that, the employee must give notice as soon as is reasonably practicable, which in practice means within seven days of learning of the date.

The written notice must state the expected date of birth, adoption or placement, and the period of leave the employee intends to take as set out in the benefits guide. For a birth, a medical certificate confirming the expected date is also required. For adoption or foster placement, the matching letter or placement notice is required instead.

Once the notice is received, People Operations confirms in writing within fourteen days that the leave has been approved and states the exact start and end dates. If the dates need to change, which they often do, the employee must tell People Operations as soon as possible and at least twenty eight days before the planned start date where that is practicable. The company will always try to accommodate a change in dates, and the benefits guide explains how the weeks may be split.

During parental leave the employee's role is held open. A returning employee comes back to the same role, or to a suitable alternative role if the team has reorganised while they were away, and the manager and People Operations discuss any changes with the employee before they return. An employee on parental leave stays in contact with the team only if they want to, and the company does not expect it.

## 8. Questions and where to find things

This handbook is one of three documents that describe working at Aurora Labs. The benefits guide covers pay, insurance, retirement and leave entitlements. The remote work policy covers working from home, equipment and the coworking allowance. The information security policy covers the rules that keep our customers' data safe, and every employee must read it in their first week.

Questions about this handbook go to People Operations through the help desk. Questions about money, whether an expense is claimable or how to submit it, go to Finance. Questions about equipment go to IT. Anything that feels like it does not fit a category should still be raised, because the help desk will route it.